Blanquerna–Ramon Llull University, School of Communication and International Relations, Official Master's degree in Advanced Studies in International Affairs

Subject:Introduction to Political Science (141148 - Supplementary course) – 2025-26

Titles of the two Essays :

What do you think are the main challenges democracy faces today? Do you think it is in crisis? Discuss

Is there a place for democracy at the global level? What type of governance should be adopted to address global conflicts and challenges?

VEZIO TRISTAN

Professor : Jaume López

I hereby declare that this assignment was written by me, in my own words, except for texts either quoted directly or paraphrased, which are clearly indicated and acknowledged as such. I also declare that this assignment was written without the use of any Artificial Intelligence (AI) software like ChatGPT, Deepl, Grammarly and similar to them. Full bibliographic details are given in the reference list, which also contains any internet sources including the URL and access date.

This work has not been submitted to any other examination authority either at Blanquerna School of Communication and International Relations or elsewhere.

I am aware that the incorporation of material from other works or the paraphrasing of such material without acknowledgement, as well as the use of AI software for the writing of this project, will be treated by the Faculty as academic fraud-plagiarism.

ESSAY 1 : What do you think are the main challenges democracy faces today? Do you think it is in crisis?

If we follow the *Freedom in the World Report,* published in 2024 by the thinktank *Freedom House*, only 19% of the world population lives in fully considered democracies, and the decline affected more than 40% of the global population, a figure that is in constant decline in recent years. Democracy has been challenged and redefined throughout the years. If we go back to the classics, Democracy comes from Greek *Demos* and *Kratos,* which means literally, *the people rule.* It has, for centuries, been considered as the most free, equalitarian, and guaranteeing the most liberty system in a political society and a certain goal to achieve for all societies. But, it has taken different forms, regarding the challenges of societies in their time. In Ancient Greece, participation was limited, without women, slaves or foreigners, whereas, in Tocqueville's democracy, in the late XIXth century, the universal suffrage, and individual liberties were key. Nowadays, and as Larry Diamond explained, coining the key term of *Democratic recession,* democracies are in a key turning point, where in our political modern system, democracies were the rules, nowadays, it is starting to be the exception. But how can we explain this? Do Democracies, originally defined as a western political concept, enter in a new phase of decline, facing challenges that were never so new and threatening, and letting emerge the term 'crisis' or is it simply a deep change in the concept of democracy that will redefine the concept ?
This essay will tackle this theme, analyzing what for me are the most important threats of democracies nowadays, studying both dimensions of a threat, first in the challenges inside the very own democracies, to focus then, question the external threat, on a more global scale.

What is crucial for me nowadays, in the democracies in the 21th centuries, and moreover, since the pandemic, that challenged the traditional links between the notion of power and citizens and the relationship between a political power, and the society, is the challenge regarding legitimacy. Legitimacy is defined by a recognition by the citizens that a government, a political party, a leader, has the right to govern. It depends on the citizens trust in the institution and system. However, we clearly face today in the western democracies, a crisis of representation, and therefore a crisis of legitimacy. The French Sociologist, Pierre Rosanvallon, in 2008, defined democracy's legitimacy crisis, as a crisis of confidence. It was true, nearly twenty years ago, but it's even more true, in political actuality nowadays. The rhetorical frame, that somehow, political institutions, governments, and even their own political figures, are seen as distant, unresponsive, self-serving and disconnected from the reality of the 'real' people, would make them illegitimate to govern. Look for example, French political debates nowadays : a president, doubly elected, by free elections, organized, scheduled in advance, and elected by the own french *peuple,* would be illegitimate to govern, because of political instability, and an 'inefficient policy' since his election nearly ten years ago. This illegitimacy would come from a fracture between what is defined by the *people* and the *elite.* This dangerous rhetoric, consisting within the very own society, separates and classifies people, regarding their social background, their salary, their work or origins and classifying them as *legitimate* or *illegitimate* is a very dangerous game. However, this is not new, and it tackles our very own second, threat : the rise of Populism.

The decline of Trust, in democracies and political powers, and this disconnection that we talked about, makes a very fertile field for the rise of *populism.* In Populist, rhetoric, there is the sense of belonging to a class that is neglected, rejected, and a claim that democracy is only for the wealthier. It can be summed, by the fact of taking all the main issues, that the society is facing, using the 'disregard' of what is perceived as elites, and say what the crowd would like to hear. There are the one inside, and the one outside. It is used, as a political tool and even weapon, from within the democracies, from political parties, and figures that are often represented as anti-system, but who intentionally use the system for their own benefit. For example, the *Yellow Vest* movement in France, between 2018 and 2020, was originally a movement expressing anger at fuel taxes, economic inequality, perceived government elitism, and lack of trust, but, and this is important, without political etiquette. It has evolved in an anti-system mobilization, exploited by populist parties worldwide, re-using the rethorics that we saw earlier. It was a real, all-out attack, within the constitutional frame, against the system. In this sense, populism is both a symptom and a response to legitimacy issues. The traditional, conventional, channels of democratic process are challenged and therefore a part of the democracy is challenged too.

The next two challenges would be the product of a very 21st century phenomenon : the ubiquity of technology, that comes to challenge democracy, in the more 'natural' way of a form of this democracy. Liberty of Speech and the right to access proper information. Because we live in a democracy, liberty of speech is a right that is guaranteed. But, if I use my 'liberty of speech' to threaten my very own democracy, calling for civil unrest, overruling governments, or the law of my proper country, that gave me this right, how can this democracy respond? Is she right to do so ? This is also a challenge for democracy nowadays : Digital disinformation, social media unrest, political violence through social media and a lack of contrasted information that unequivalently, creates, what Eli Pariser, calls filter bubbles. We tend to watch and to learn, isolated in our own behaviour. The Digital manipulation of the information, represents a challenge nowadays because information is much more accessible quicker and more broad than before. The last, but not the least internal challenge, is economic polarization that has blurred perceptions that democracy serves the goals of the wealthy rather than the common interests.

However, internal challenges that democracies face are mingled, with external factors, and challenges that could help us think that yes indeed, democracy is challenged. The German sociologist, Ulrich Beck, defined the notion of *"cosmopolitan democracy"* which could be defined as the goal for democracy, to thrive, and to expand beyond national borders, with global institutions democratically accountable (Beck, U, 2006). But, this vision comes in a time, where democracies start to be the exception, and not the rule. The term Illiberal Democracies, start to emerge, becoming a sort of hybrid regime, in a time where sovereignty is each time more and more contested. In this context, the main challenge that would damage the image of democracy, will be the growing risk of a *technocratic* government and governance in the international system. Decision-making will convey the message of unelected experts,a democracy that would be efficient, but very much

disconnected from the citizens. But is democracy in crisis ? Can it renew its model, to tackle the 21st century ?
This answer depends on what we define by the term “crisis”. If by crisis, we mean decline, violence, and unrest, yes many factors indicate that democracy is declining, in terms of effulgence. The rise of populism, the growing polarization of civil society, and the violence that seems to be each more the rule, the answer will be “yes”. However if by crisis, we mean, evolution and adaptation, i would say, that it’s in transformation, in evolution. Democracy is not always judged by elections, but more as the global system, through social movements or civic engagement. From a personal perspective, I think that democracies are, in a standpoint. As political theorist John Dewey once wrote, *“The cure for the ills of democracy is more democracy.”*(Dewey,1939). In the face of deep polarization, disinformation, inequality, and the rise of authoritarian alternatives, democracy today confronts serious challenges both within and beyond its own borders. However, to say that democracy, as a concept and all, is in crisis, would be too simple. More than crisis, I would say that democracies today are indeed under strain, from polarization, disinformation, and economic inequality to global authoritarian pressures. Yet these challenges do not necessarily mark democracy’s decline, but rather its transformation. We are in a defining moment, where a political model, such as democracy, that defined, liberal western world, in politics, needs to be adapted to 21st century reality.

ESSAY NUMBER 2 :

Is there a place for democracy at the global level? What type of governance should be adopted to address global conflicts and challenges?

We live today in a deeply interconnected world. Never before in history have the destinies of countries been so closely connected. A virus that appears in one part of the globe can disrupt economies on different continents; carbon outputs from a few nations can change the climate for everyone; and disputes previously considered "local" now resonate in worldwide markets and migrations. Political systems are, for the vast majority, also, been modelated, to fit in a model represented by some core values, that are supposed to represent the values of the majority and are interconnected. Yet, one question arises : Can a system traditionally thought to remain in the national borders, be commonly accepted and impose itself in the global agenda, and if so, how could we manage it in the reality of the 21st century, marked by tensions, wars, and each time more *realpolitik.* We will try to answer these questions in this essay following the frame in a positivist way. On the one hand we will see that, yes, there is a place for democracy at the global level but that, this place, is each time questioned, and dwindling away. This would be the focus of our second part, showing the challenges faced. Finally we will ask ourselves, if a more practical and less institutionalized type of government wouldn't be the key to tackle the 21th century challenges.

In 2024, and following the World Trade Organization figures, the total of the global trade market would represent 32.200 billion dollars, representing an increase of 4% compared to the figures in 2023. These increases, represent in part, a world that is each time more

interconnected, that can be translated into our topic : Yes, global democratic participation is not only desirable, but really necessary. Global challenges, needs global solutions, and we see this everyday, regarding Climate Change, pandemics, financial stabilities, or even wars. Following this logic of interdependence, global democracy appears not only as a goal to reach, but foremost as a moral imperative for all Nations, calling themselves “democratic”. We know that Democracies are following the principles of freedom, morality, and justice. However, these democracies are not only seeking this for their own freedom, but it’s a political model that tends to spread, and has the goal, to reach even the most remote parts of the world. There is an important component of ethics, within the democratic values, promoting freedom, mutual recognition, and it’s possible thanks to morality and justice. For this part of the essay, I helped myself with the work of David Held and Daniele Archubugi, which is an article published in the newspaper, Ethics & International Affairs, from the Carnegie Council for Ethics and International Affairs *(Ethics & International Affairs, no. 25 (2011)* in which they define the political framework and theoretical approach of this vision : Cosmopolitan democracy.

It advocates for the democratization of global institutions such as the United Nations, the International Monetary Fund, and the World Bank, guaranteeing that they reflect not just states but also the individuals directly impacted by their decisions. In this regard, the establishment of global citizenship, an identity that goes beyond national boundaries,would allow individuals to engage in influencing choices that affect the entire planet. In this sense, of course they is a place for democracy at the global level. I would also argue, personally, that democracy at the highest level of cooperation is possible, not only because of shared values, or the cooperation, but also because, it’s a concept that is rooted, within first Western, but nowadays a nearly universal ideology. Today, to take a few examples, France, Germany, Spain, Canada, Mauritius (who has the only African country with a full democracy, and it tops the list with a democracy index score of 8.23.), Singapore, Uruguay, Costa Rica or Chile have this goal to achieve a fully and prosperous democracy. We can clearly see a start of developing ethos, in a globalized area, that, indeed, democracy has a place in the highest and global level, and that a citizen should be involved in this process.

But, these are the objectives. In reality, nowadays, democracy at a global level, seems to sway and be more a political tool, regarding the context and the *realpolitik.* What do we mean by “Global Level” ? Do we mean that we, as human beings, tend to find a collective and globally shared democracy ? Today we are far from this. The international system, nowadays, and this echoes, directly to our theme, lacks cooperation. The primary challenge is the lack of a true worldwide feeling of connection and sense of belonging. There is no common Global level. Each one strives for their own benefits and interests. The *Demos,* in the sense of a community of citizens that shares common values, is more than fragmented. Language, Historical questions, religions, are still nowadays an obstacle for the rising of a global governance. Speaking of governance, there is a clear lack of translation from ideals to reality. Even though, international system thrives for equality between members, which is also, a requirement in all due democratic system, the fact is, that the system is clearly asymmetrical, and on a global level, nowadays goes more with power, force, and imposition, than with cooperation, dialogue and rationality. Democratic coordination is, yet, considered, but not as a

primary factor. It's clearly visible nowadays in the North/South dialogues, for example, regarding the responsibility of Climate Change, or in terms of international trade, where sanctions are imposed, through the value of tariffs, and unilaterally spoken. In short, democracy is ruled out, when a big power dictates what to do, or not to do, to a weaker power. It questions, then, the meaning of the word "democracy", and tends to think that maybe the word "oligarchy" would be more suitable to the reality of politics on a global level. Moreover, global democratic powers are challenged by the rising of new hybrid powers, in the same global scenario, that influence global affairs. For example, how can democratic values be reinvigorated, when, the global market, of a product, for example, is in the hands of multinational corporations, lobby groups or in the case of ressource, in the hands of autocratic governments. All these actors escape democratic control and policy of transparency. We can clearly see then, that Democratic values are constrained by the reality of power, and fragmentation resources that are vital for the economies, in a more global and interconnected world.

As we saw, current international structures are very limited. But, maybe, the solution lies in changing the focus of the question. In my opinion, the future of global democracy does not lie in creating new institutions, which, throughout history, was already done, but in making the ones that are existing, nowadays, work effectively. For example, The U.N nowadays, is reflecting a world that is no longer existing. It lies in post World War two realities, and more democratic reforms would be needed. For example, nowadays, Global South represents the ⅔ of the working age population, 40% of global energy and transitional metal production, a quarter of global trade and a quarter of inward foreign direct investment. However, this reality has not always been transfigured through the decision making, and can feel neglected by the international system particularly in the decision making of the council of Security of the U.N, represented by the World War Two winners. To fill the gap, more transparency, more accountability would be needed. We saw that this was possible, on an international and local level. The governance should be more practical and maybe less institutionalized. Touch reality of the field, more than distant policy making. At international level, we saw this was possible, in the 2015 Paris Climate Agreement, with a real commitment at a national level, that was transposed to international level. On a local scale, France implemented in March 2010, the QPC, or, priority question of constitutionality. It was at this moment, a new type of governance, to reinforce democracy at a local level. This mechanism, permitted, for everyone of the 66.6 million French citizens subjected to jurisdiction, and above 18 years old, to contest in a trial the validity of a law, voted in both chambers of Parliament. This is in my opinion a very interesting question, without entering political-fiction, that could be raised on an international level, to vivify democracy on a more broad scale. Engaging oneself, in global policy issues and hearing different dissonuous voices, to create debate, and therefore, democracy. This, in a more theoretical approach, was tackled by political scientist Elinor Ostrom, when she offered the theory of *polycentric governance.*(Ostrom, 2010). Maybe this is one of the solutions to the question raised by this essay. Instead of relying on one system, composed by 4 or 5 major institutions that tackles all the subjects of international policies, it would be interesting, to create intersecting center of decisions, based on local cooperation and local approach, to tackle global issues such as climate change, but in a very local and

pragmatic way to be more efficient, to really see the field. It has already been done, and proved its efficiency at a local level, when the project of the C-40 Cities emerged, with the lema, *when local actions meet global ambition.* The objective is to tackle the issue of climate change, influence global agenda and protect communities. Major cities such as Paris, Barcelona, London, Mexico City, Milan, Lima, L.A or States-cities such as Singapore, have already joined the project.

Following this point of view, Yes there is a place for democracy at the global level. It's what we call Global Governance and principles such as democracy, freedom, are the foundation of these policies. However, to make this system work, the type of governance must be reinvented and modernized. The international system cannot continue living in a post world-war two, with for example colonial heritage, reality. It must adapt to the 21st century, which is a far more complex reality and start a more flexible, more horizontal participation. In my opinion, global governance is somehow contested, because it lacks what is the most important thing : globality. We have to go forward, looking for more multilateralism, and as we saw, a polycentric framework of governance, but that would not affect global trade and governance. The objective is to make it more efficient. It would mean integrating regional and international organizations, robust involvement from civil society, and technological resources to improve transparency and participation. Decision making, will therefore be more legitimate and more easy with a democratic involvement that would be reinforced. Each member of the international community would have a voice in a more fair environment.

BIBLIOGRAPHY AND SITOGRAPHY ESSAY 1 AND 2, harvard Style

Essay number 1:

Beck, U. (2006) *The Cosmopolitan Vision*. Cambridge: Polity Press.

Diamond, L. (2015) 'Facing Up to the Democratic Recession', *Journal of Democracy*, 26(1), pp. 141–155.

Freedom House (2024) *Freedom in the World 2024: The Mounting Damage of Disinformation*. Washington, D.C.: Freedom House. Available at: https://freedomhouse.org (Accessed: 7 November 2025).

Pariser, E. (2011) *The Filter Bubble: What the Internet Is Hiding from You*. New York: Penguin Press.

Rosanvallon, P. (2008) *La légitimité démocratique: Impartialité, réflexivité, proximité*. Paris: Seuil.

Tocqueville, A. de (2000 [1835–1840]) *Democracy in America*. Translated by H.C. Mansfield and D. Winthrop. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Dewey, J. (1939) *Freedom and Culture*. New York: G.P. Putnam's Sons.

Liberties. (2025). *Rule of Law Report 2025*. Liberties European Centre for Civil Liberties. https://www.liberties.eu/f/vdxw3e

Essay number 2 :

Archibugi, D. and Held, D. (2011) 'Cosmopolitan Democracy: Paths and Agents', *Ethics & International Affairs*, 25(4), pp. 433–461.

Held, D. (1995) *Democracy and the Global Order: From the Modern State to Cosmopolitan Governance*. Cambridge: Polity Press.

Ostrom, E. (2010) *Polycentric Systems for Coping with Collective Action and Global Environmental Change*. Global Environmental Change, 20(4), pp. 550–557.

World Trade Organization (2024) *World Trade Statistical Review 2024*. Geneva: WTO Publications. Available at: https://www.wto.org (Accessed: 7 November 2025).

C40 Cities (2025) *C40: Cities Leading the Way*. London: C40 Climate Leadership Group. Available at: https://www.c40.org (Accessed: 7 November 2025).